

Call Centre Operations

Every call is an opportunity to build trust.

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1. PURPOSE

This SOP establishes the standards, procedures, and expectations for all call centre operations at [Company Name]. It covers inbound and outbound call handling, agent conduct, performance management, and escalation protocols. The goal is to ensure every customer interaction is handled professionally, efficiently, and consistently.

2. SCOPE

- All call centre agents, team leaders, and supervisors
- All inbound and outbound customer calls
- All channels handled through the call centre including voice, callback, and voicemail
- All shifts — morning, afternoon, evening, and weekend

3. ROLES & RESPONSIBILITIES

Role	Responsibility
Call Centre Agent	Handle all inbound and outbound calls, log interactions in CRM, meet performance targets, escalate where necessary
Team Leader	Monitor agent performance in real time, handle escalated calls, conduct daily team briefings, provide coaching and feedback
Quality Assurance (QA)	Listen to and score recorded calls, provide feedback to agents, identify training needs, report quality trends
Workforce Manager	Manage agent scheduling, monitor call volumes and wait times, ensure adequate staffing across all shifts
Call Centre Manager	Oversee overall operations, review performance reports, manage team leaders, liaise with other departments

4. CALL CENTRE HOURS & STAFFING

Shift	Hours	Days	Minimum Staffing
Morning	7:00 AM - 3:00 PM	Monday - Saturday	[X] agents
Afternoon	3:00 PM - 11:00 PM	Monday - Saturday	[X] agents
Weekend	8:00 AM - 5:00 PM	Saturday - Sunday	[X] agents
Public Holidays	9:00 AM - 3:00 PM	As gazetted	[X] agents

NOTE: Staffing levels must be reviewed monthly against call volume data. Understaffing during peak hours must be escalated to the Workforce Manager immediately.

5. WORKSTATION & SYSTEM SETUP

All agents must complete the following setup at the start of every shift:

◆ 5.1 Pre-Shift Checklist

1. Log in to your workstation and verify all systems are operational
2. Log in to the telephony system and set your status to 'Available'
3. Log in to the CRM system and verify your queue assignments
4. Check the daily briefing board or team communication channel for updates
5. Ensure your headset is working and audio levels are correctly set
6. Review any open cases or callbacks assigned to you from the previous shift
7. Confirm your break schedule with your Team Leader

◆ 5.2 System Issues

- Report any system issues immediately to your Team Leader or IT support
- Do not attempt to resolve technical issues independently
- If the telephony system is down, follow the Business Continuity Plan (BCP)
- Document all system outages with start and end times in the incident log

6. INBOUND CALL HANDLING

All inbound calls must be handled according to the following standard process:

◆ 6.1 Call Answer Standard

- All calls must be answered within 3 rings — this is a non-negotiable standard
- If a call cannot be answered within 3 rings, the system will route to the queue
- Agents must not allow calls to ring out — always answer or transfer to queue
- Never put a customer on hold without first asking their permission

◆ 6.2 Standard Call Flow

#	Stage	Action
01	Greet	Answer with the approved greeting script. Introduce yourself and the company warmly and professionally.
02	Verify	Verify the customer's identity using at least 2 security questions before discussing account details.
03	Listen	Allow the customer to explain their query fully without interruption. Take notes in real time on the CRM.
04	Acknowledge	Acknowledge the customer's query or concern with empathy before providing a solution.
05	Resolve	Provide the solution or information. If you need time to check, inform the customer and place on hold with permission.
06	Confirm	Confirm that the customer's query has been fully addressed. Ask: 'Is there anything else I can help you with today?'
07	Close	Close the call with the approved closing script. Thank the customer and wish them well.
08	Log	Complete all CRM notes and call disposition codes within 2 minutes of the call ending (After Call Work).

7. APPROVED CALL SCRIPTS

All agents must use approved scripts as a guide. Scripts may be personalized in tone but the core content must remain consistent.

◆ Opening Script

USE FOR: All inbound calls

Thank you for calling [Company Name]. My name is [Agent Name]. How may I assist you today?

◆ Identity Verification Script

USE FOR: Before discussing any account information

For the security of your account, I will need to verify your identity. Could you please confirm your [full name] and [ID number / date of birth / registered phone number]?

◆ Hold Script

USE FOR: When placing a customer on hold

I just need a moment to look into that for you. Would you mind if I placed you on a brief hold? It should be no longer than [estimated time]. Thank you for your patience.

◆ Transfer Script

USE FOR: When transferring a call to another department or agent

I am going to transfer you to our [department name] team who will be best placed to assist you with this. Please hold while I connect you. Before I transfer, I will brief the next agent so you don't have to repeat yourself.

◆ Closing Script

USE FOR: Closing every call

Thank you for calling [Company Name], [Customer Name]. I'm glad I could assist you today. Have a wonderful [morning/afternoon/evening]. Goodbye!

◆ Difficult Customer Script

USE FOR: When a customer is angry or frustrated

I completely understand your frustration and I sincerely apologize for the inconvenience. I want to make sure we resolve this for you. Let me [action]. I appreciate your patience.

8. OUTBOUND CALL HANDLING

Outbound calls are made for callbacks, follow-ups, surveys, and proactive customer communications. All outbound calls must follow these standards:

◆ 8.1 Pre-Call Preparation

8. Review the customer's account and interaction history before calling
9. Confirm the purpose of the call and have all relevant information ready
10. Ensure you are calling from an approved company number
11. Schedule outbound calls within business hours — 8:00 AM to 6:00 PM

◆ 8.2 Outbound Call Flow

12. Introduce yourself and the company immediately upon the call being answered
13. Confirm you are speaking with the correct person before proceeding
14. Clearly state the purpose of the call
15. Handle the query or follow-up as required
16. Confirm the customer is satisfied before ending the call
17. Log the call outcome in CRM immediately after the call

◆ 8.3 Unanswered Outbound Calls

- If the call is unanswered, attempt a maximum of 3 times before leaving a voicemail
- Voicemails must include: your name, company name, reason for calling, and callback number
- Log all unanswered attempts in the CRM with timestamps
- Do not leave sensitive account information in a voicemail

9. HOLD & TRANSFER PROTOCOLS

◆ 9.1 Placing a Customer on Hold

- Always ask the customer's permission before placing them on hold
- Inform the customer of the estimated hold duration
- Maximum hold time is 2 minutes without checking back
- Check back every 2 minutes to update the customer and confirm they are still holding
- Never abandon a customer on hold — if you must leave, arrange a callback

◆ 9.2 Transferring a Call

- Explain to the customer why you are transferring and who they will be speaking with
- Brief the receiving agent before completing the transfer — warm transfer is preferred
- Never cold transfer a customer without informing them
- Confirm the transfer was successful before disconnecting
- If the transfer fails, apologize and handle the query yourself or escalate to Team Leader

10. ESCALATION PROCEDURE

Not all calls can be resolved at first contact. Use the following framework to determine when and how to escalate:

Trigger	Action	Escalate To
Cannot resolve	Inform customer you are escalating and explain why	Team Leader
Angry/abusive customer	Warn the customer and if necessary escalate immediately	Team Leader
Legal or regulatory threat	Do not make any commitments; escalate immediately	Call Centre Manager / Compliance
Fraud suspicion	Do not alert the customer; flag immediately to supervisor	Fraud / Compliance Team
Media or PR risk	Do not engage; escalate immediately	Call Centre Manager / PR Team
System outage impacting customer	Log the issue and escalate to IT immediately	IT Support / Team Leader

11. AFTER CALL WORK (ACW)

After Call Work (ACW) is the time an agent spends completing tasks immediately after a call ends. This is a critical part of the call handling process.

- ACW must be completed within 2 minutes of the call ending
- Log a complete and accurate summary of the call in the CRM
- Select the correct call disposition code from the approved list
- Create or update any tickets, cases, or tasks arising from the call
- If a callback or follow-up is required, schedule it immediately
- Set your status back to 'Available' as soon as ACW is complete

NOTE: Prolonged or excessive ACW time negatively impacts queue wait times and team performance metrics. Team Leaders will monitor ACW times in real time.

12. PERFORMANCE METRICS & TARGETS

All call centre agents are expected to meet the following key performance indicators (KPIs). These are reviewed weekly by Team Leaders and monthly by the Call Centre Manager.

Metric	Target	How It Is Measured
Average Handle Time (AHT)	< 4 minutes	Total call time + ACW time divided by number of calls handled
First Call Resolution (FCR)	> 80%	Percentage of calls resolved without the customer calling back within 24 hours
Customer Satisfaction (CSAT)	> 85%	Post-call survey scores collected after each interaction
Service Level (SL)	> 90%	Percentage of calls answered within 20 seconds
Call Abandonment Rate	< 5%	Percentage of customers who hang up before being answered
After Call Work (ACW)	< 2 minutes	Time taken to complete CRM logging after each call
Schedule Adherence	> 95%	Percentage of time agent is logged in and available as scheduled
Quality Assurance Score	> 85%	Average score from QA call evaluations per month

13. QUALITY ASSURANCE

Call quality is monitored through regular call evaluations conducted by the Quality Assurance team.

◆ 13.1 Call Evaluation Process

- Each agent will have a minimum of 5 calls evaluated per month
- Calls are evaluated against the approved Quality Scorecard
- QA scores and feedback are shared with agents and Team Leaders weekly
- Agents scoring below 75% will receive immediate coaching and a performance improvement plan

◆ 13.2 Quality Scorecard Components

Evaluation Area	Weight	What Is Assessed
Opening & Verification	15%	Correct greeting, identity verification completed
Active Listening	15%	Did not interrupt, took accurate notes, understood the query
Product & Process Knowledge	20%	Accurate information provided, correct processes followed
Communication Skills	15%	Clear, professional, empathetic tone maintained throughout

Resolution & Accuracy	20%	Issue resolved correctly or appropriately escalated
Closing & ACW	15%	Correct closing script, CRM updated accurately and on time

14. AGENT CONDUCT & PROFESSIONALISM

◆ 14.1 Do's

- Always be polite, patient, and professional regardless of the customer's tone
- Use the customer's name at least twice during the call
- Speak clearly at a moderate pace — especially when giving reference numbers or important information
- Be honest — if you don't know the answer, say so and find out
- Thank the customer for their patience at every opportunity
- Keep personal conversations off the floor during working hours

◆ 14.2 Don'ts

- Never argue with a customer or match their aggression
- Never make promises you are not authorized to make
- Never discuss customer account information in a public area
- Never use slang, jargon, or unprofessional language
- Never eat, drink, or chew gum while on a call
- Never access a customer account without a valid business reason
- Never share system passwords or customer data with unauthorized persons

◆ 14.3 Managing Abusive Callers

18. Remain calm and lower your tone
19. Acknowledge the customer's frustration: 'I understand you are upset and I want to help you'
20. Issue one clear warning: 'I want to assist you but I need us to communicate respectfully'
21. If the abuse continues: 'I am unable to continue this call while you are speaking to me this way. I will end this call and a supervisor will call you back within [timeframe]'
22. End the call and immediately notify your Team Leader
23. Document the interaction in full detail in the CRM

15. ATTENDANCE & SCHEDULE ADHERENCE

- All agents must be logged in and ready to take calls at the start of their shift
- Lateness of more than 5 minutes must be reported to the Team Leader in advance

- Unplanned absences must be reported to the Team Leader at least 1 hour before the shift starts
- Break times are allocated by the Workforce Manager — agents must adhere to their break schedule
- Agents must not extend breaks beyond the allocated time
- Schedule adherence is monitored in real time and forms part of the monthly KPI review

NOTE: Three instances of unexplained lateness or unplanned absence in a month will trigger a formal performance discussion with the Team Leader.

16. BUSINESS CONTINUITY

In the event of a system outage, natural disaster, or other disruption to call centre operations, the following business continuity measures apply:

- The Call Centre Manager must be notified immediately of any disruption
- Agents must switch to the manual logging process and paper-based scripts
- The IT team must be contacted immediately for system issues
- If the call centre cannot operate, calls will be routed to the backup site or IVR
- All decisions during a business continuity event must be documented
- A post-incident review must be conducted within 24 hours of the disruption ending

17. REPORTING

Frequency	Report	Audience
Daily	Call volumes, service level, abandonment rate, AHT	Team Leaders & Call Centre Manager
Weekly	FCR, CSAT, individual agent KPIs, QA scores	Call Centre Manager & Operations
Monthly	Full performance report, trend analysis, training needs	Senior Management
Quarterly	Strategic review of operations, SOP updates, benchmarking	Executive Leadership

18. DOCUMENT CONTROL

Version	Date	Author	Changes
1.0	May 2026	Milkah Muchunu	Initial version

